

trends can be immediately recognised, quashed, and positive trends can similarly be analysed, attributed and improved upon.

Open Source ERP

Before open source ERPs began to appear, companies could either purchase / rent ERP solutions for high prices, or they could implement their own solution, which took time and money, and itself needed to be maintained. Open source ERPs provide a perfect middle ground.

Open source software is touted with its many benefits in almost every field of computing, but where it can really shine is when people can actually utilise the code. For most people who are not developers, software being open source does not help much. The code is out there but there is little chance you will ever be able to use it, all you can comfort yourself with is the fact that it being open source means development on the software should always continue in some form.

Enterprises can surely benefit from the community support and a wide developer base, however companies can gain even further benefit as they have the capacity to hire developers to customise and optimise the software to their exact needs. They can develop additional modules in case some functionality is missing, or remove functionality to improve performance and ease of use.

That is not all, since the software is open-source they don't have to wait for the software company (or in this case community) to fix bugs.

Another possible advantage with open-source software solutions is that you could possibly integrate the best functions of different open source solutions into a single package (although with the different architectures of such software it is difficult to imagine this case). For companies that plan to shift from a proprietary solution to an open source one, the company can choose to mimic the old interface, to make it easier to transition.

With OSS enterprises can develop additional modules in case some functionality is missing, or remove features to improve performance and ease of use

In the end, for companies that have the capacity, going open source can not only save money, but also give the company a more powerful and integrated organisational framework catered directly to its needs. No longer will they have to pay huge sums of money for software that might not end up meeting their needs, or purchasing software that the company might abandon later on. With the source code in their hands, they can lead the development even if no one else is there.

The open source disadvantage

While many people appreciate the power of open source, when it comes right down to it, many companies prefer to use

proprietary software that comes with a support contract (although some open source ERPs are also offered with support or even commercial licences). The open source aspect is endearing, but if the organisation lacks in-house IT skills, the flexibility, and customisability of the software is lost to them.

When you have your own customised and home-developed solution for ERP, you are bound to find that you are dependent on the original developers for continued upgrades. With changes in the development team due to any reason, there could be significant problems – to alleviate these, make sure throughout development that the code is well documented and commented.

Conclusion

Open source is creeping into the most unusual places, and it is best that you take advantage of this. The open source community is teeming with brilliant products that can help optimise your organisation to the best and fullest, and open source ERPs represent a brilliant consolidation of some of the best open source technologies out there.

You need not look at open source ERPs as an endpoint for your needs, but more as starting points upon which you can build your organisation's infrastructure. This might seem like a lot of unnecessary work, when so many commercial implementations exist, however once you are done with the effort, you will have a much more streamlined and optimised solution that is best suited for your needs. **d**

OPEN SOURCE ERP SOLUTIONS

There is no shortage of open source ERPs today, which just goes on to show how diverse the open source community really is. While commercial ERPs can cost the company millions to implement, open source solutions are essentially free!

Opentaps

Open taps is a flexible ERP software package built on open source technologies such as Apache Geronimo, Tomcat, and OFBiz, and can run on a variety of open source and commercial databases. The software itself is available in a modified version of the GPL.

It is built on a Service Oriented Architecture, which means that the functionality of the software is provided by loosely coupled services. In such architecture, each service provides functionality for one task, and by combining these services in the required pattern, you can accomplish complicated tasks. This also makes the system very flexible.

Compiere

Compiere is a professional ERM solution that has a commercial backing. Unlike opentaps, it espouses a Model driven architecture, in which the model of the data is used to generate the procedures that define a process. This means that as the company's requirements change, and the more, and different kinds of information need to be collected, the structure of the database can be changed with ease. Compiere's use of the MVC paradigm, allows this information to be presented using multiple views, which can be modified to accommodate each company's special needs.

The company behind Compiere also provides professional versions which come at a subscription price, and support more features. While long criticized for only running on propriety Oracle database servers, it is well on its way to develop support for open source database servers such as MySQL, PostgreSQL etc.

ERP5

Based on the Zope server this ERP5 is another

open source ERP under the GPL. Similar to Compiere it too is available in a paid version as ERP5 Express which comes a SaaS.

The 5 in ERP5 is not based on a version no, but the five principles of Resource, Node, Path, Movement, Item which are employed in ERP5. Where resources are as their name suggests, the resources available to the company such as products in an inventory, machines in factories etc. Nodes represent points which deal in resources, such as bank accounts which deal in the resource of money, or a manufacturing plant which deals in raw resources and finished resourced. Paths define the procedure of exchanging resources between nodes. Movements represent the actual utilization of paths to move resources between nodes. Finally, Items are instances of resources, such as a printing press is an item that represents a resource.

ERP5 utilises these concepts in creating "business templates" which define the core functionality. It has been awarded the Best ERP Implementation by "Decision Informatique Professional Magazine".